

Bound to the Rotation

T.S

A woman of the Church must witness the trials of those who have left Earth, never to return.

Kiara rested her hands on her knees as she waited for the group to enter the conference room. Her skin was fading at her fifty years, a far cry from the youthful vigour they had held when farming the fields. An eternity ago now.

Now she was the Shepherd of People. The title from the Celestial Church filled her with bitterness. But she would continue to fulfill her role to the letter, without letting emotion interfere. As she had done for the last couple decades. Nothing would change.

Right?

A circular table sat in front of her, the empty chairs already populated by two people. They stared with wide eyes at the metal bullworks surrounding them, and the thin glass that was all that stood between them and the vast, starry blackness outside.

A holographic fiction. Steel was the only way to protect yourself from the vacuum of space.

More people strolled in, until one out of the four required was all that was missing. Kiara ground her teeth. Patience. This was another of countless Rotations. Yet she wanted to get this over with as quick as possible.

The Witnessing was always the worst. When she had to understand the horrors that made these people actively choose to participate in a Rotation.

Kiara knew better. Almost no one was here for friendly reasons.

She could try not to care. Cut off all her emotion, soldier through the confessions she was about to hear.

But she never could. And with caring comes the worst part of all.

Not being able to do a damn thing about it.

Finally, when a man with dirty smirk sat down, Kiara clapped her hands.

"That's everyone."

Four people sat around the table. Two men and two women. A fifth man stood next to the seated elderly woman.

She had read all their files. Except for the standing man. Probably a carer.

"And you are?" She asked.

"Julian," He whispered in reply.

"Do we really have to be here?" Steven interrupted with a whine, young mouth pouting as his hand unconsciously smoothed his black fringe.

Elly nodded in agreement, her long red braids bouncing over her shoulders.

"I'm not sure I understand the question, you all chose to be here." Kiara replied.

Alvaro, still grinning a smile that didn't reach his eyes, raised both hands up in the air.

"He doesn't mean on the spaceship.

He means do we have to be here, in this room, for the 'Witnessing.' It's been gods knows how long since you've been on Earth.

What could you possibly provide us?"

The others nodded in agreement. Except for Julian. He seemed to be staring into space, his face haggard with black circles under his eyes. The older woman sitting, Brianne, had her eyes closed.

"This is a landmark occasion. The Witnessing is tradition to honour that."

And instrumental in weeding out the heresy, Kiara thought to herself. It may not have happened for a while, but there was still every chance that she would stop one of these people from returning to Earth.

For some, it might be a blessing.

"That's a load of crap. I reckon you're fishing for info on behalf of the church." Alvaro spat. "How are you going to use it against us hey?"

Kiara narrowed her eyes.

"Fine. Let me make this clear. Finishing a Rotation can be, no, is one of the most traumatic experiences a human can go through. It can completely deconstruct your reality.

So, this discussion, or Witnessing, is important. It is to remind you of who you are, why you are here and to consolidate what you want from the Rotation.

We all know that the majority of those on a Rotation are here to transform themselves into a different person. You won't be able to do it if you don't speak about *why* you are here.

The truth can be difficult. But it is liberating."

Except for the prison it leaves me chained in.

Alvaro snorted again but didn't reply. It may have been because his comrades in arms were nodding in agreement.

"So, I ask again, who will start? No-one? Do I have to pick a name out of the hat?"

Steven raised a tentative arm.

"I ... I can go."

“Great.” Kiara held out a hand, directing him to begin.

“I don’t know what to say.”

“Why don’t you begin by telling us what made you decide to apply for the Rotation?”

Steven frowned, swept his fringe to the side of his head, and blinked rapidly. Until he stopped, landing on the answer.

“I saw the ad on the side of the building.”

“And Steven, what exactly were you doing when you saw that ad?”

His head twitched as he moved it from side to side, lips closed.

“It’s alright. I know it can be hard to say. But this is the Witnessing. The only way you will be able to return to Earth is if you tell the truth.

No-one will judge you.”

Steven clenched and unclenched his hand.

“I ... I saw the ad when ... I ... was about to jump off the building next to it.”

He dropped his head to his chest. His confession produced a gasp from Elly.

It didn’t stop Alvaro from smiling, and Julian continued to stare forward with dead eyes.

Kiara didn’t feel much. She had heard it so many times before, she’d even guessed it as soon as she had seen Steven.

Yet a faint bubble of emotion still managed to formulate in her chest, despite her attempts to crush it. She needed to be stone.

“Why were you feeling that way Steven?”

“It was my ... brother. I was with him when he died.”

Once he had said his secret, it didn’t take long for Steven to begin speaking without hesitation.

Funny that about pain. The longer we keep it buried, the faster it can flood out.

“I wanted to do right by him. And when Dad left and Mum started having ‘Her Time’ on the couch with her eyes all empty every night, Tim needed someone. It was just us two, and I made sure to feed him, get him warm, I even got him this cute little fluffy bunny that he would take everywhere he went.

We were doing good! We didn’t need anyone else. It was Tim’s idea that we run away, that we didn’t need Mum, didn’t need the stinkin’, ugly Dads she would bring back to the house.

So, one day, after I came home to Tim’s mouth bloody and Mum lying on the couch, I decided to do it. To run away.”

“That’s a fucking dumb idea ...” Alvaro interjected until Kiara shushed him.

"No interruptions during a Witnessing! Please Steven, continue."

He bit his lower lip.

"That first night, we took the train into the city. Tim loved all the neon lights, the cars that floated off the ground, there were so many people around! I had to stop him running up to one lady with metal rabbit ears on her head. Maybe I should have let him, but Mum always said *these new robots were bloody nuffties*.

Tim and I managed to live. We scavenged food, met other kids, and I was big enough to beat off anyone who tried comin' up to us for no good.

But ... but ... that's when Tim got sick."

Tears started swelling in Steven's eyes, and Kiara felt her throat constrict.

Stone, she was stone.

"I tried everything you know. Asked people for medicine, said I was a good hard worker. All I got was a few hard whacks for it.

Tim, poor sweet Tim, with his blonde hair, the freckles on the side of the nose. His cute smile that always made me feel fuzzy inside. He was still smiling when I left for food and came back to his eyes closed. He didn't deserve it. HE DIDN'T DESERVE IT!"

Steven slammed both fists on the table. Everyone clenched their faces, even Julian was focusing on the boy with a look of sorrow. Bridgette remained lost to her own devices.

"I didn't know what to do after that. Found myself up a buildin'. Was gonna step off into those neon lights, until I saw the ad.

In those few good days, when it was just us two in our little nock on the side of the road, outside of the loud noise, Tim would look up to the sky and every now and then, when the gas, the steam weren't cloudin' everything, he would ask, *where do the bunnies go to play Stevo?*

And I would say, *up there in the black Tim. See those white dots all around? Each one is a little bunny hopping around.*"

Steven brought out a toy. It was fluffy and despite having been cleaned, brown specks of mud were stuck in the faded white coat.

"I wanted to make his dream come true. Let his rabbit out into the sky. But it won't bring him back.

Nothing will."

Steven choked the words out, tears free flowing. He buried his face into the toy, sobs smothered in its fur.

The table stared at him. Kiara bowed her head, and her lips curled as she spat out the words.

"Your wants, your needs, your sorrows have been witnessed Steven. You have been judged, and your sacrifice to the Rotation has been acknowledged."

"What sacrifice was that?" Elly asked. "You think he's going back to anything better?"

Almost certainly not, was what Kiara wanted to say, what screamed in her head. Yet that wasn't her role. She was an impartial arbiter, to hear their confession, and judge if they should be allowed back onto Earth. Nothing more.

It didn't stop her stomach recoiling at the foulness of her next words.

"The Rotation will give him a chance for a new life. Sometimes that's all there is too it."

Alvaro chuckled.

"I reckon it'll just give him the chance to jump off another building, but this time, it'll be significantly higher."

Elly stared daggers at him.

"How could you possibly say that?."

Alvaro pointed at the still sobbing teenager.

"Look at him. He is all by himself. They say when you finish a Rotation you get some quick cash, 'a new life'. How long is he going to be in this 'new life' until the memories and pain of everything we left behind, of everything we sacrificed comes back? Life doesn't just restart at the flick of a switch. He needs help, and I can't see anyone doing that."

"Maybe you could be his new family? Meet the new world head on with him?" Elly asked.

"Fat chance of that. Don't need someone else to let down." Alvaro whispered, turning his head to look at the stars.

Kiara seized the moment.

"Alvaro, I think this is a perfect time for you to begin your Witnessing."

"I would argue that it's the perfect time for you to get fucked." The smile was back on his face when he swore at her.

"If you would like to complete your Rotation, this needs to be done. You are here for a reason."

Kiara pressed when he refused to reply.

"Why are you here Alvaro?"

Alvaro continued looking at the panel, at the bleakness of space. How long can endless black really capture your attention?

"My god, we're going to be here forever aren't we?" Elly interrupted.

"Shut up. I don't need your prattle in my ear." Alvaro hissed back.

"Well you're going to get it. I actually have real reasons to be here, unlike you. What are you? A slimy entrepreneur, trying to make a quick buck? Putting some dollars in the bank and then going for a Rotation, hoping the interest will go up so your akin to a billionaire when you return? Let me tell you, the bankers are already onto that, there's no way in hell you will see a real investment ..."

"I'm not here for the fucking money!" Alvaro yelled, spittle flying. He breathed heavy, staring at Steven whose head was still buried in his toy, and ran his face through his hands.

"Then, Alvaro, tell me why you are here." Kiara wondered if the people in front of her could tell how hard she struggled to force the words through her cramped throat.

When he looked at her, Kiara saw the raw emotion.

"I got caught alright. Wasn't much, just a few grams is all. High powered stuff sure, but nothing that wasn't out of the ordinary. People always going to be shoving stuff up their nose, I'm just part of the system that gets them what they want.

Wrong place wrong time I guess. Don't know what happened, don't know why, just know that they needed to make an example of someone.

Thought it'd be run of the mill when I got cuffed. Then the judge sent me down to the johnny for twenty years. *Twenty!*

I hadn't done nothing, hadn't shot anyone. If I sold all the product I had on me, the money wouldn't last me a month.

I didn't know what to do. Stewed in a cell for a couple of months. Best I could have gotten was to get out in twelve years on good behaviour. But then some suits came and found me, brought me into a nice room. Gave me some good food, promised me some money, I smelt a rat, but let them say their piece.

They said that they wanted me to go for a Rotation. Something about making sure people from all walks of life were on the ship. And that I didn't seem like the violent sort to cause any mischief."

Alvaro trailed off and rubbed the back of his head.

"And you said yes?" Kiara asked.

"What do you take me for? I told them to go to hell." He snorted before continuing.

"The only problem was that they wouldn't take no for an answer. Sprouted something religious bullshit. That I've already been chosen, that any change to the lottery would be a sin."

Kiara nodded.

The Rotation was sacrosanct. If you were chosen in the Lottery, many considered it to be God's divine, holy judgement, and that it must be followed.

Despite the assurances of the Church, the Lottery was plagued with questions of corruption.

Kiara still held faith. But if you wanted to get rid of someone, a Rotation was a pretty effective way of doing it.

Regardless, if you were chosen for a Rotation, it meant you were going.

It was wrong to Kiara, not that she would publicly disagree with the Celestial Church.

But it seemed that more and more people were excited in choosing people to go on a life-changing Rotation, than question whether it was right to do so.

"I kept telling them no. That's when they started offering me money. And not for me, although I'm sure I'll come back to a good haul when we get back.

For my family and all. Numbers that made my eyes go wide.

I kept haggling until I realised that there was no point, they didn't have a limit. So, I took the cash and here I am. You happy?"

Kiara opened her mouth until Elly spoke over her.

"Did I not say it? While I might not be the best with people I am very good at analysing the evidence. You're here for the money."

Alvaro clenched both hands tight.

"I told you ... I ... I," he snarled.

"There won't be any violence here Alvaro. Why did you take the money?"

"I did it for my daughter."

"And, how does that make you feel?"

He hissed, gripped his fists.

"Like there's a burning fire in my throat."

Kiara could feel it inside of herself.

"I'm sure you will get some of her recordings."

"But I won't ever see her again!" He screamed. Tears streamed down his cheeks.

"It will be a hundred years when we get back to Earth!

I won't have aged a day and when we return, all that will remain of my beautiful daughter is her gravestone.

And I did it for her. I get punished with life, with losing everyone and everything I know.

But, I just did it for her." He sobbed, burying his face in his hands, his moans echoed by Steven who still hadn't moved.

Why did Kiara do this?

Everyone who sat in front of her was just a dam waiting to break. And she could do nothing to help them.

Was she breaking them so they could be rebuilt? So they could remake a life for themselves on Earth?

Yet how many people had she sent back onto the planet she would never again set foot on. She had worked out that when she left for the next Rotation, within an hour for her would be three months for them.

Looking at the two crying men in front of her forced her to wonder.

Would it take thirty minutes or an hour for their blood to leak into Earth's soil after she had waved goodbye?

Or would it take less?

"Your wants, your needs, your sorrows have been witnessed Alvaro. You have been judged, and your sacrifice to the Rotation has been acknowledged. I am sorry for your loss." Kiara blinked at her deviation. Elly was staring at her with a frown, yet it seemed no one else had noticed. She moved on to the woman.

"Elly, it is your turn. Why are you undertaking a Rotation?"

The red-haired woman rushed through her words quickly.

"Oh, I couldn't think of anything better to do with my life!"

She didn't even look at the sobbing people on either side of her.

"A Rotation has to be one of the greatest innovations humanity has ever created!

The possibilities are endless. I mean, if you told someone that they could go on a holiday for a couple of weeks and then come back and *one hundred years had passed*? Or, to correct Alvaro, more like one hundred-thirteen years and five months pending any deviations to the flight path.

Well I put my hand up. I didn't believe I had a chance, I'm sure every fellow scientist also would have made every effort to get their name on this decade's Rotation.

So, I made sure to splash some cash to ensure the lottery spat out a number that may or may not be in my favour."

Kiara frowned. Inside she didn't care, but the routine forced her to say the words.

"The Rotation Lottery is incorruptible."

"Right and the woman with the best ideas gets into the scientific journal before the man. Lady I might have my head half the time in a textbook, but I know how the real world works.

And now I'm here! For a quick rotation around the sun in a spaceship, and then I can get back to my work that has had over a century to grow."

“And what is your work?”

“I’m a dendrologist, or more colloquially, a botanist. I study plantlife, with a focus on trees.

It can be a cruel field, what with people more interested in blowing things up and polluting the world they grew up on. Not to mention the purported irony of my life’s work.

I could plant a whole field and never see the beauty I had created.

Until now.”

Elly spread her hands out and leaned back in her chair.

“Before leaving, I made sure to plant a variety of flora. I have my own private property, a few acres, that will now be growing the most exotic amount of plant-life. It will be my own personal forest.

I am so excited to study it all, see how my chemically engineered seeds fare compared to their natural counterparts. Not to mention how the extinct species I have created in the lab I may see spreading throughout the world.

What I have done is one’s lifework, and I will be able to see it, live in it, *relish* it, all in the blink of an eye!”

Kiara tried to latch onto her enthusiasm. It wilted away inside of her like a rotting daisy. Nothing could grow in the bleak desert that was her heart.

“I can see that you have much to gain from the Rotation. It is ... pleasant. Most do not seem to cherish the ... gift that is the Rotation.”

Elly shook her head.

“Which is crazy. Everyone is here to gain something.”

Alvaro looked up at that.

“What could we possibly be gaining you crazy bitch.”

Elly pointed at Steven.

“He is here to fulfill the final wish of his dead brother. You are here for your family, to provide for them a life that once was too far-fetched. We all know why the elderly push through the masses to get their place on the Rotation, although I will let the old woman tell her own story.

The Rotation is a gift. Something to celebrate, to feel overjoyed about the fact that we are some of the lucky few to be allowed this opportunity. And not because of the Celestial Church, but because of the science behind it.”

“You do not hold faith with the Church?”

Elly snorted at Kiara’s question.

"Are you serious? I'll throw that one back at you. You are forced to remain on this rig for the rest of your days. Never to see the land you grew up on. Do you still hold faith?"

Kiara hoped Elly didn't see her swallow.

"My duty is sacred, and one that I preserve to endeavour in to my utmost ability."

"I've seen less slop in social media posts. You can't even say the Witnessing address correctly."

Kiara felt her frustrations begin to boil. Quickly, she smothered her need to argue back, folding back into the routine she had been doing for years.

Or millennium, depending on how one looked at it.

"Let's get back on track. Your joy is exciting, however, this is the Witnessing. We have seen you wants and needs.

What are your sorrows Elly?"

She smiled.

"Ah yes, the script. Well, to make sure everything goes according to schedule, to ensure my estate is secured, I had to leave my partner down on Earth. He will be gone when I return, compost for the plants he helped grow. I am sorry that he will never see what I will.

But in the name of science, his sacrifice will be worth it."

Kiara nodded.

"Thank you for your contribution.

You're wants, your needs, your sorrows have been witnessed Elly. You have been judged, and your sacrifice to the Rotation has been acknowledged."

"Let's just get this done as quickly as possible please." Elly replied with a smile. Kiara agreed, although even the person who was happy to be here made her feel just as disheartened as those who were depressed.

Was it because she was envious that they themselves could express how they feel?

"Brienne. Welcome. Could you please tell us why you are here?"

Brienne's hair was grey, her arms were yellow and wrinkly, the veins in her limbs and neck the only vibrant colour in her skin. She said nothing, didn't even register Kiara's comment, staring into the wall at nothing.

"Please ma'am, it is important that you speak."

The man next to her, Julian, finally looked up, leant down and whispered something in her ear.

"What, more noodles need rolling? Well, get the soup going for the customers and I'll get it done!" Brienne started moving her arms over the table, fingers carefully moulding air.

Julian dragged a hand down his face before looking at Kiara.

"I am sorry, sometimes, no, all the time, she doesn't know where she is.

Has Alzheimer's you see. I will be speaking on her behalf."

"I understand. Has the Celestial Church officially recognised you as patron of Brienne?"

"Yes."

"Then proceed. Please, tell us why you are on the Rotation."

"Isn't it obvious? We're here because she has Alzheimer's. A terminal illness.

My mother got the luck of the draw and managed to get a ticket onto the Rotation. She might still die, but there's a chance that in a century there's a cure.

A miraculous, wonderful cure that hasn't been created in the last five hundred years despite humankind being able to send ships into space.

But I'm sure that this century, the one where instead of living my life, I'm hurtling through the cosmos on a fucking rock, is the one where we will cure it."

Kiara inclined her head.

"I can sense some frustration."

"You could say that."

"Is it because you are worried that a cure might not be ready when you return?"

Julian stared at the roof, his face constricting with emotion.

"No."

"Then what makes you feel this way?"

Julian's cheeks twitched, and a raspy sob rose out of his throat.

"Because I chose to leave them all behind."

"Them?"

"My wife. My daughter. My ... infant son." Julian faded away, staring in the corner. Kiara waited. She didn't have to wait for long.

"When my mother got sick, I felt like the world went dim.

When I visited, sometimes she would recognise me, question why she was sitting in a white, subdued, nursing home. It was sweet.

It made every other visit so much more sinister.

Can you imagine the person you've grown up your whole life knowing, your own mother, becoming a dim-witted husk?

It was horrible, yet I kept going to see her. Half because I was the only one that would. And the other half was because maybe, just maybe, this would be one of the good times. When she would smile, recognise me, say how much she loved me, how much she missed me. How these small bright moments were just enough for her to keep fighting.

I didn't have the heart to question whether the fight was even worth it.

Eventually I stopped coming as frequently. My daughter was in primary school, the baby a struggle as my wife and I worked to keep the bills up.

I didn't have the time.

That's when I got the news. The nurses had entered her into the Lottery.

And, Brianne, my dear, stupid, senile mother, decided to be lucky enough to win. And now I'm here.

I lost my whole life, but at least I did what's right. Instead being with my wife, my kids, knowing that my own baby will have lived a whole life without me and be dead when I get back ... well at least I'm here." Julian snarled the final words, tears coalescing in the sides of his eyes.

"Why didn't you let her go without you? Anyone could have gone with her, I'm sure there would have been countless volunteers who would leap at the chance.

Or even one of her nurses might have made the decision to accompany her. Why did you come on the Rotation Julian and leave it all behind?"

His sigh was racked with sobs, yet his voice was clear.

"She has Alzheimer's. It is horrendous, for both the family and the patient. I've seen her at her worst, when she is crippled with fear, when my own mother doesn't know where she is or who she's with.

The embarrassment, when simple tasks are suddenly unreachable for her.

The horror, when I watch it all unfold within the what? Half an hour I spend in the centre with her?

Her being cured of it would be wonderful. Or would it? What would really happen if they do magically fix her? Let's say we come back down to Earth, one hundred and thirteen years after we have left, and there's a cure.

Do you think my Mother will actually be cured if I'm not with her? Everyone she would have know would be dead. Every place she grew up could be rubble.

If I'm not with her, then she'll have the literal equivalent of Alzheimer's.

She will just be a frail old lady, left in the wilderness, conscious, but alone.

Alone. Like I will be when she passes. I'm alone.

Alone.

But ... at least, she won't be."

The tears stopped and Julian stared at the wall. Steeled in his decision.

"You're wants, your needs, your sorrows have been witnessed Brianne ... and Julian. You have been judged, and your sacrifice to the Rotation has been acknowledged.

Congratulations, everyone has completed the Witnessing."

Two crying men, two people staring into space, and a smiling woman rubbing her hands in excitement.

An average session.

Kiara stepped up to leave.

"What about you Shepherd? What are your sorrows?" Elly asked.

"The Celestial Church forbids me from espousing my own emotions in the sancity of the ..."

Alvaro thudded his hand on the table.

"Oh spare us the bullshit. You can piss off or speak. But not the trash. We want to leave that behind."

Kiara swallowed and faced them.

I have to sit here and listen to the horrible lives of men and women, every day, who have chosen to leave the planet I will never set foot on again. And I must shut my mouth and nod and fret and give a fuck, which I do, which I so do, all I want to do is help but I'm stuck on this rock ...

Kiara shook the fire out of her.

"My sorrows are your sorrows. I am here to help you. I am here to guide you. And saying any more may interfere with your own journey."

She turned away. It killed her that she did. But it was who she was. Bound to empathise.

Bound to serve.

But most of all, bound to the Rotation.

The End

